A Land Swap Stirs Debate on Wild Cumberland Island

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Wild horses, **feral** hogs, and deer roam free on Cumberland Island, Georgia, an 18-mile barrier island off the Atlantic coast. Its salt marshes, **maritime** forests, and untouched beach, reachable only by ferry, make it among the most ecologically diverse islands on the coast. The National Park Service has managed it since 1972, including about 9,800 acres of **wilderness** Congress said 'shall be permanently preserved in its primitive state.'

But the island holds more than **wilderness**: **relics**, mission remnants, plantation ruins, and grand homes built by Gilded Age industrialist Thomas Carnegie and his wife Lucy. Carnegie descendants still live or vacation here on private land, and the park service has proposed a land swap with them, allowing new construction.

Under the proposal, parkland on the island's west side would go to two branches of Carnegie descendants for up to eight new private homes. Park superintendent Melissa Trenchik says gathering private ownership on the west side would let the park better protect natural and cultural sites on the Atlantic side, where development could then be banned.

Trenchik calls the eight homes 'modest,' saying they would face permanent conservation limits. Critics disagree, noting the 15,000-square-foot allowance, including driveway and outbuildings. 'We're swapping for McMansions,' said Joseph Manning, an attorney with Defenders of Wildlife.

Barclay McFadden, a descendant of Thomas Carnegie, calls the fears about mansions 'so unfounded.' 'Five generations have been buried there,' he said. 'For our children and our grandchildren, it's a sacred place.' He says his family has been 'wonderful **stewards** of the island.'

Naturalist Carol Ruckdeschel, 85, has lived on the island for more than 50 years and is one of the main voices against the swap. She worries it is the 'first nose under the tent' toward more development, and says the island should stay a pure **wilderness**.

Word Treasure

feral -- Describing an animal that lives wild, not as a pet or farm animal.

maritime -- To do with the sea or the coast.

wilderness -- Wild land where nature is left alone and few people live.

relics -- Old things left from the past.

stewards -- People who look after and take care of a place.

Background you need

A national park is a large area of land that a country protects so its nature and history can stay safe for everyone to enjoy.

Barrier islands are long, narrow islands off the coast that protect the mainland from storms and waves, and their marshes and forests are home to many kinds of wildlife.

Sometimes private land sits inside or beside a national park, and the park service may trade land with the owners to bring the park's most important places under its care.

When a trade like this is suggested, people often disagree about whether new building will harm the wild land or help protect it.

Break it down

LEAD: The National Park Service has proposed a land swap on Cumberland Island, Georgia, that would allow up to eight new private homes.

KEY EVENT: Parkland on the island's west side would go to two branches of Carnegie descendants.

+- WHO: Park superintendent Melissa Trenchik proposed the swap; critics include Joseph Manning of Defenders of Wildlife and naturalist Carol Ruckdeschel.

+- WHAT THE PARK GAINS: Private ownership gathered on the west side, so the park can better protect natural and cultural sites on the Atlantic side, where development could then be banned.

+- WHAT CRITICS FEAR: Homes as large as 15,000 square feet, a first step toward more development.

EVIDENCE: The island has about 9,800 acres of wilderness that Congress said should be permanently preserved in its primitive state.

OPEN QUESTION: Whether the swap will protect the island's wild land or open the way to more building.

Why it matters

Cumberland Island is one of the most ecologically diverse islands on the coast, so the choice between new homes and keeping it wild will shape what this rare place looks like for future visitors and wildlife.

Test what you remember

1. What kind of island is Cumberland Island?

- (A) An island in the middle of the Pacific
- (B) A man-made island near a city
- (C) A small island in a lake
- (D) An 18-mile barrier island off the Atlantic coast

2. How long has the National Park Service managed the island?

- (A) Since last year
- (B) Since 1900
- (C) Since 1972
- (D) For about ten years

3. What would the land swap allow?

- (A) A hotel on the Atlantic side
- (B) A new ferry to the island
- (C) Eight new national park offices
- (D) Up to eight new private homes on the island's west side

4. Why does Melissa Trenchik support the swap?

- (A) It would let the park sell the whole island
- (B) It would let the park better protect sites on the Atlantic side, where building could then be banned
- (C) It would remove all the wild horses
- (D) It would bring more tourists to the island

5. Why do critics object to the plan?

- (A) They want the Carnegie family to leave at once
- (B) They say the homes would be too big, pointing to the 15,000-square-foot allowance
- (C) They think the ferry should be free
- (D) They want the island to become a city

6. What does Barclay McFadden say about his family?

- (A) They built the ferry to the island
- (B) They have never lived on the island
- (C) They have been wonderful stewards of the island
- (D) They want to sell all their land

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: C 3: D 4: B 5: B 6: C

Questions to think about

1. Park superintendent Melissa Trenchik: Says gathering private ownership on the west side would let the park better protect natural and cultural sites on the Atlantic side, where development could then be banned, and calls the eight homes modest.

2. Critics, including Joseph Manning of Defenders of Wildlife: Say the homes would be far too big, pointing to the 15,000-square-foot allowance, and call the plan swapping for McMansions.

3. Barclay McFadden, a Carnegie descendant: Calls fears about mansions unfounded, says the island is a sacred place where five generations of his family are buried, and says his family has been wonderful stewards of the island.

4. Naturalist Carol Ruckdeschel: Worries the swap is the first nose under the tent toward more development and says the island should stay a pure wilderness.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):